

Wandering The Alley:
A Guide to A Chicago Alleyway

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Preface

Alleyways are often dismissed as spaces of transition—backdrops to urban life, neglected and unseen. Yet, within their narrow confines lies a microcosm of resilience, adaptation, and interconnection. This guide invites readers to look beyond the surface, to uncover the layered stories of an urban alleyway, drawing on influences from art, ecology, history, and poetics.

The conceptual underpinnings of this work are rooted in the idea of noticing—of paying close attention to the margins. Anna Tsing’s *The Mushroom at the End of the World* highlights “the art of noticing,” encouraging us to see life thriving in unexpected places, even amidst ruin (Tsing 2015). Similarly, julie ezelle patton’s *Arkitext* challenges us to look beyond the apparent, to embrace the richness and complexity of spaces that might otherwise be ignored (patton 2024). John Muir Laws’ techniques for auditory mapping further emphasize this approach, helping to hear spaces anew and trace the rhythms of life that often go unnoticed (Laws 2017). Dilip da Cunha and Rachel Havrelock’s insights on water highlight its interconnectedness—moving between places and states, shaping the landscapes and histories it touches (Cunha and Havrelock 2024). These perspectives inform the ecological and poetic lens of this guide, which seeks to make visible the vitality of the overlooked.

This work is also shaped by the relationship between waste and renewal. Agnès Varda's film *The Gleaners and I* explores how discarded materials are repurposed into sustenance or art, a theme that resonates with the alley's cycles of decay and transformation (Varda 2000). Walt Whitman's *This Compost!* similarly reframes decay as fertile ground for life, a metaphorical and ecological insight that guides the writing style and thematic focus of this field guide (Whitman 1855).

The alleyway's history as part of the Hyde Park area is another central element. Drawing on research from the Hyde Park Historical Society, I trace the space's transformation from a portage route traversed by the Council of Three Fires to its current state as an urban corridor (Hyde Park Historical Society 2024). This layering of histories mirrors the transient yet persistent nature of the alley itself.

Finally, the guide's structure is inspired by the rituals of CAConrad and their approach to writing as a practice of deep engagement with place (CAConrad 2021). By combining observation with reflection, the rituals outlined in this guide aim to foster a deeper understanding of the alleyway's ecosystem.

Through these conceptual frameworks, this field guide seeks to redefine how we see and interact with spaces like alleyways. It is an invitation to notice, to glean, and to embrace the stories embedded in the margins of the city.

I Introduction

I.I Why Alleyways Matter

Alleyways are spaces of transience and permanence, resilience and decay. Often relegated to the margins of urban life, they serve as thoroughfares, dumping grounds, and hidden ecosystems. Yet, their overlooked nature makes them essential—places where human activity intersects with the natural world in unexpected ways.

This guide focuses on a single Chicago alleyway, a space shaped by human infrastructure but teeming with non-human life. From the plants that root themselves in pavement cracks to the animals that navigate discarded waste, alleyways reveal a dynamic relationship between built environments and natural processes. Historically, alleyways have been spaces of movement and adaptation. The alley behind my home lies on land once traversed by the Council of Three Fires, possibly functioning as a portage route long before it was framed by dumpsters and asphalt. Today, the transient paths of raccoons and sparrows mirror its past role as a corridor for life.

In studying this space, I hope to illuminate the interplay of resilience and resourcefulness that defines alleyway ecosystems. Whether it's the repurposing of waste through gleaning or the adaptability of plants and animals to urban conditions, the alleyway offers lessons in coexistence and sustainability.

1.2 How to Use This Field Guide

This guide is structured to blend practical information with poetic reflection. Each chapter focuses on a specific aspect of the alleyway's ecosystem, from its flora and fauna to its geological history and seasonal rhythms.

You can use this guide in several ways:

- **As a field resource:** Identify species, track changes, and observe the interconnected systems within the alley.
- **As a creative prompt:** Let the poems and reflections inspire your own writing or art.
- **As a lens for understanding:** Consider how marginal spaces like alleyways reveal broader themes of adaptation, resilience, and sustainability.
- Each section includes a **"You May Find"** list, mimicking traditional field guides, as well as poems and essays that delve into the complexities of the alleyway environment.

Whether you approach this guide with scientific curiosity, artistic intention, or a desire to see the urban world anew, it is an invitation to wander and wonder.

2 Cognitive Maps

Maps, essential tools for human civilization, have guided us through physical and digital landscapes. From ancient cave paintings to digital globes, they have helped us understand, explore, and shape our world.

Maps not only navigate us but also visualize the distribution of phenomena, inform critical decisions, and preserve cultural heritage. We interact with them through traditional paper maps, digital platforms, and immersive virtual and augmented reality experiences.

Beyond their traditional role, maps can be powerful instruments for social and environmental change. By incorporating artistic expression and ecological considerations into mapmaking, we can foster community engagement, promote environmental awareness, and advocate for social justice.

Maps, once static representations of space, are dynamic tools that shape our understanding of the world and our role within it. By embracing their potential as instruments of art, science, and social justice, we can create a more sustainable, equitable, and inspiring future.

Both ways—each side is an entrance, or an exit.

One side opens only to a one-way street,
a dead-end alley, its few ways narrow,
certain. The other side stretches to two-way
roads, branching, further freedom in
leaving. But for now, I'm here. Squirrels fight
atop the dumpster, claws scratching against
plastic, a quick movement—then silence.

Beneath the stairs they dart, kicking
up dust and dirt, tracing a map of lives unseen.
Birds—picking their way around the dumpster,
hopping, stopping. Eyes fixed on the ground,
tiny scavengers in the waste we forget to see.

The red brick here feels rough, weathered under
morning light, sun-bleached, paler on one side
where it faces the dawn. Each brick holds a
layer of color stripped by sun. Old metal
chimney hatch, cold to touch. Was it here last
year? I've never looked, but there it waits, unmoved.

Telephone pole: scarred by claws, squirrels
marking their territory with tiny, insistent lines. A climb,
a territory, a moment left behind. Linda passes by on
her bike—gravel crunches under wheels, a
faint "hello" in the air. I don't answer. This is a
moment for silence, for alley sounds only. The hum
of gas engines, small cars rattling against gravel.

And electric cars—a stranger sound, clean,
smooth, too new. Sirens in the distance, a faint,
constant echo, a reminder of life beyond this hidden space.

The dumpster thuds, a squirrel moves within,
rustling through castaway bits—disturbed and startled as I approach,
it leaps out at me. Blue guard railing, cold, unyielding,
protecting a tiny parking lot where my car rests, though
I mostly ride my bike. A kick, trash scattering, loose and
untethered. A huge mess near the new garage where they
gutted the house—rebuilt it down to structure, leaving scraps
in their wake. Cold leaves layered in the overgrown gangway,

dark and tangled. This is the place I'd explore as a kid, hidden and wild, waiting to be walked through, imagined.
The wall—grooved, a patchwork of colors. I remember a couple painting it last summer, layer after layer of paint,

as if searching for something smooth. I thought of easier ways to finish, but maybe they knew best. A screw,
half-buried in the sandy soil, its green paint chipped and cracked. Maybe from the old fence, torn down in spring.
I miss the old fence—this new green one, flimsy, cost us the shrubs, cut away to make room. This screw is all that's

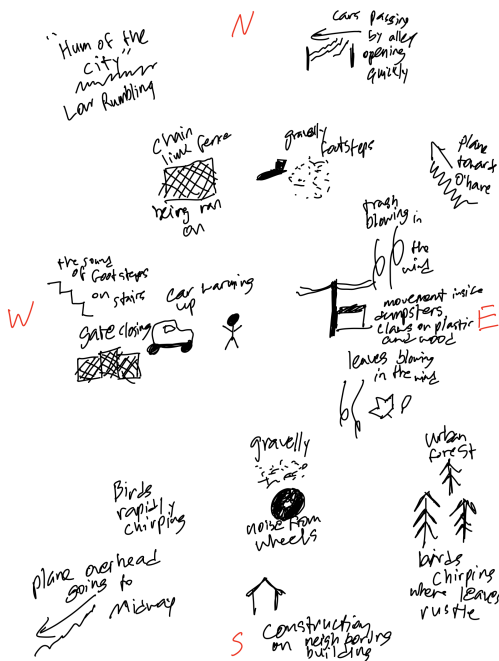
left. A plant, small, herbaceous, a splash of green pushing through sandy dirt. Soil, likely dumped here from
garden bags at some hardware store. I think back to a summer, when I hauled thousands of these bags, soil thick
with potential, and once, loaded seventy-five into the trunk of a Tesla. This plant was never meant to be here. It
simply is. A popper toy, left dirty and alone by the new garage. No children at the construction site, so maybe it
was a worker's—or a child's gift. Imagining hands, passing it along to a stressed parent. Strange to leave it here,
forgotten. A power adapter, useless now, buried in the dirt. Testament to the international students living nearby,
discarded as they settled, moving on, each [adapter](#) a trace of a journey, no longer needed. Grooved wall again. I

touch it, remembering again—tiny greens sprouting, persistent by the green fence, defiant in their unchosen
place. Roots twist through concrete, holding fast in cracks, tiny fists against the stone. Birds calling, faint. Sirens
blending with wind, voices at a distance. The hum of cars; the crash of unseen objects, brief, forgotten, falling.

This is a place of life and return. I watch
insects dart, ants crossing cracked pavement, each
small life here, a part of this alleyway's hidden
history. I stand still. Both ends open, neither fully
entrance or exit. My eyes close, breath deep, release.
What does it mean to say that life belongs only to one
place when it is all so interconnected like water?

This alleyway, a site of return, of resilience,
where things left behind are never truly alone.

2.1 Sounds of the Alley



The hum of the city to the north holds everything together, a low, constant murmur beneath the shifting layers of sound. Leaves and trash tumble in parallel rhythms, pushed by the same wind. Birds call from the trees, where branches creak, their voices co-mingling like neighbors sharing stories.

A squirrel's path maps itself in sound: the hollow clang of a trash can, the scrape of claws against a telephone pole, the metallic rattle of a chain-link fence. Planes carve invisible lines overhead, their directions hinting at distant destinations—Midway to the south, O'Hare to the north.

Gravel crunches only beneath the weight of people and cars, the other creatures gliding silently over the pavement. Footsteps on the stairs precede the creak of the gate, the rumble of an idling engine. Wooden planks shift and settle as construction continues on a neighboring building.

The alley is shaped by its sounds, layered and interwoven, as seasonal as the shifting air. The rustling of wind through leaves mirrors the scraping of trash—a shared motion, a shared moment. Some sounds belong to many places at once, like bird-song in the trees or the brief Doppler swell of a passing car at the alley's mouth.

This place isn't static; it hums and flows, a system of interactions more alive than it seems. Each sound traces its own map: local movements, distant migrations, the rhythm of living here and now. Together, they mark the season, the time of day, the presence of the alley as a space of connections rather than divisions.

3 Flora

Overview

Resilience weaves through the flora of the alleyway, transforming cracks and shadows into sites of defiance and regeneration. In the dynamics of invasive species and native plants, the alley becomes a microcosm of transience and survival.

3.1 Life in the Cracks

Where persistence finds root among neglect

In the cracks, *Viola sororia* hums a violet symphony,
a ground cover for forgotten dreams.
The lion's tooth, *Taraxacum officinale*, grins gold,
its seeds parachuting promises to where hope clings thin.

Mosses of *Dicranum*, soft as whispers,
turn sidewalk shadows into green cathedrals.
Above, *Ailanthus altissima*,
the “tree of heaven,” reaches uninvited,
its ambitions cracking concrete
in a baptism of chlorophyll and defiance.

You May Find

- **Wild violet (*Viola sororia*):** Native ground cover, known for thriving in shaded and compacted soils like sidewalk cracks.
- **Common dandelion (*Taraxacum officinale*):** A resilient plant whose flowers provide an early source of food for pollinators.
- **Joint-toothed mosses (*Dicranum spp.*):** Found on moist, shaded surfaces; plays a role in soil formation and moisture retention.
- **Tree-of-heaven (*Ailanthus altissima*):** Invasive species that grows rapidly, outcompeting native plants in urban settings.

3.2 Trees and Shrubs

Sentinels of the alleyway, guardians of transience

The *Populus deltoides*, cottonwood sentinel, whispers tales in trembling deltoid leaves.

In spring, *Cercis canadensis* blushes, its heart-shaped leaves pulsing pink

as if to embrace the urban ache.

The thorn-clad *Berberis thunbergii*,
a Japanese barberry armed for invasion,
sinks its roots deep, a bramble's ambition,
while *Parthenocissus quinquefolia*,
Virginia creeper with five-fingered grace,
dances skyward on brick canvases,
weaving vines into art where decay reigns.

You May Find

- **Cottonwood Tree (*Populus deltoides*):** A fast-growing native tree often found near water but adaptable to urban environments.
- **Eastern redbud (*Cercis canadensis*):** A native ornamental tree with heart-shaped leaves and springtime pink blossoms.
- **Japanese barberry (*Berberis thunbergii*):** An ornamental yet invasive shrub that tolerates poor soil and urban pollution.
- **Virginia creeper (*Parthenocissus quinquefolia*):** A native climbing vine that provides food for birds and cover for insects.

4 Fauna



Overview

The alleyway brims with life, from the scavengers navigating urban decay to the hidden lives of arthropods and microorganisms. These creatures form an interwoven narrative of resilience, survival, and the delicate balance of ecosystems in the margins of human habitation.

4.1 Scavengers and Survivors

The Tailless Squirrel in the Alley

In the alley, you dart,
A flicker of brown on grey, cracked pavement,
Running between the castaways of human life—
The urban understory—
Cardboard, plastic bags, the remnants of yesterday.
Carrying berries and fruit from man-made greenery,
No tail to steady you,
No bushy plume to mark your kind,
Yet you move, light as air,
Slipping through the urban sprawl.
Hiding in cars at night,
Fences, brick walls, power lines,
Your playground, your stage,
Do you imagine this as a forest?
In a world where nature meets street.

Without your tail, you are incomplete,
Yet more complete for it—
A creature defying its own shape,
A survivor in the debris.
The loss should slow you,

But your muscles, unseen, pulse and contract,

Firing like lightning through the sinew,
Through bones and nerve endings,
Mitochondria hum beneath your skin,
Churning energy to fuel your prance.
Cells repair the damage of the day,
Your small claws grip the jagged cobbles,
Neurons remember the cracks in the asphalt,
The scratches in the telephone poles,
The twist of the alley,
The scraps that sustain you.
In your missing tail, there is a story—
Of what you've lost,
And how you thrive despite it.

You May Find

- **Eastern gray squirrel (*Sciurus carolinensis*):** Urban dwellers that aid in seed dispersal but can damage garden plants.
- **Raccoon (*Procyon lotor*):** Omnivorous scavengers that thrive on human food waste in urban areas.
- **Cottontail rabbit (*Sylvilagus floridanus*):** Common in grassy or weedy areas; primarily herbivorous.
- **Stray cats (*Felis catus*):** Non-native predators that hunt

rodents and birds, often relying on human food scraps.

- **Brown rat (*Rattus norvegicus*):** Adaptable rodents that thrive in alleys and near human settlements.
- **House mouse (*Mus musculus*):** Small and agile, these mice often live close to food sources like trash bins.

4.2 Hidden Lives

The unseen, thriving in the margins of sight

Formica ants march, architects of soil's stories,
their armies whispering tales of hidden empires.
Salticidae, jumping spiders, pirouette unseen,
their eight eyes choreographing precision hunts.

In unseen exchanges, *Rhizobium* toil,
offering nitrogen to roots in quiet allegiance.
Actinobacteria distill decay into life's foundations,
weaving nutrient threads for plants yet to bloom.

The *Musca domestica*, housefly,
weaves between decomposition and disdain,
its hum a metronome for rot's rhythm.
Silphidae, the carrion beetle,
dances where death begins anew,

its hunger feeding the earth's endless appetite.

You May Find

- **Ants (*Formica spp.*):** Often scavengers and decomposers, they can both aid and hinder urban ecosystems.
- **Jumping spider (*Salticidae spp.*):** Small, agile hunters that control pest insect populations.
- **Common housefly (*Musca domestica*):** Plays a role in decomposition but can also spread diseases.
- **Carrion beetle (*Silphidae spp.*):** Feeds on decaying animal matter, aiding in nutrient cycling.
- **Actinobacteria:** Break down organic matter, contributing to soil health and nutrient cycling.
- **Nitrogen-fixing bacteria (*Rhizobium spp.*):** Enrich soil by converting atmospheric nitrogen into a form usable by plants.

5 Fungi

Alchemists of decay, architects of renewal

The alley holds *Trametes versicolor*,
a “turkey tail” in fungal frills,
painting wood with a prismatic death.
Aspergillus niger, the black mold,
whispers secrets on damp walls,
its spores a testament to persistence.

Below, the mycorrhizal weave whispers
through loam and roots,
its fungal strings serenading the earth.
Bread mold, *Rhizopus stolonifer*,
colonizes forgotten crumbs,
its cottony sprawl a quiet reclamation.

You May Find

- **Bracket fungi (*Trametes versicolor*):** Known as “turkey tail,” decomposes dead wood and enriches the soil with nutrients.
- **Black mold (*Aspergillus niger*):** Common on damp

surfaces, contributing to the breakdown of organic materials.

- **Bread mold (*Rhizopus stolonifer*):** Frequently found on decaying food, playing a role in organic matter decomposition.
- **Symbiotic fungi species:** Vital for plant health, facilitating nutrient and water

6 History

The alleyway behind my home lies on land once traversed by the Council of Three Fires—the Ojibwe, Odawa, and Potawatomi—who I imagine could have used it as a portage route connecting waterways vital for trade, travel, and sustenance. This space, now framed by dumpsters and cracked concrete, was possibly once a thoroughfare for canoes, laden with the rhythm of feet and voices carrying stories and goods. While urban development has silenced much of this history, echoes persist: the transient paths of raccoons, the migration of sparrows and starlings, and the cycles of waste and gleanings mirror the portage's past functions, creating a layered ecosystem of movement and adaptation.

6.1 Has This Place Always Been Transient?

Once, this alley was a waterway,
a portage path carried by bare feet,
canoes carved from cedar
gliding over shoulders,
their weight balanced by riversong.

Now, it is a corridor of concrete,
where dumpsters hum with flies,
and weeds clutch cracks in asphalt,

their green defiance
a whisper of something older.

A raccoon scuttles,
its paws leaving prints in oil spills,
a reminder of those who crossed before:
the ripple of moccasins,
the hushed exchange of goods,
each step a promise
of return or departure.

In this space of passage,
migrants gather:
sparrows from across the Atlantic,
their cries mingling with car alarms.
The Norway rat, uninvited but enduring,
knows no borders—only shadows.

Even humans move through,
stooping to glean
the forgotten and discarded.
A can becomes a dollar.
A mattress, a bed.
Every object reimagined,
its journey redefined.

Beneath the hum of modern life,

can you still hear
the Council of Three Fires?
Do their voices linger
beneath the drone of air conditioners,
the rattle of garbage trucks?

Was this place ever still,
or has it always belonged
to the passing-through,
to the ones who make their homes
where others do not linger?

Here, permanence is an illusion:
a dandelion's roots grip the soil,
but its seeds scatter.
And we, like the alley,
are only ever
becoming.

7 **Geology and the Built Environment with the Natural**

Where bedrock meets brick and roots reclaim the cracks

The Alley's Substrata

Beneath the asphalt lies a forgotten story,
a quilt of glacial till and ancient loam.
The city rests on limestone shoulders,
its bones quarried and molded into mortar.

Concrete reigns above,
cracked by roots of *Populus deltoides*,
by frost's unyielding patience,
by the silent labor of *Dicranum* moss.
Man's hand imposes permanence,
yet water and wind insist on erosion.

Alley stones carry more than weight:
they cradle the echoes of portage routes,
Council fires, the soft tread of moccasins
that marked a forest path long before
tires left their tar-streaked signatures.

Here, the natural and built worlds collide—
roots interlaced with rebar,
lichen creeping along brick seams,
fossilized shells buried beneath sidewalk grime.
The alley endures, but it is not still.

8 Weather and Water

8.1 Storm Water Pathways

Flowing through alleys, tracing transient histories

In the storm, the alley holds its breath,
a floodplain in miniature.
Rivulets of rainwater sketch temporary rivers,
collecting whispers of refuse:
plastic lids, cigarette butts,
shards of glass refracting an overcast sky.

The asphalt remembers every deluge,
its surface a map of fissures,
where weeds sip what lingers.
Downspouts cascade with urgency,
pouring into gutters that ache
for the earth they replaced.

And yet, water dreams of freedom.
In its cycle, it carries histories:
a cloud's distant origin,
a drop's fleeting touch on ancient stones,
a journey from river to sea,
from storm drain to sewer.

This alley is its pause,
a resting place for the transient
on its endless voyage.

8.2 Seasonality

Time walks through the alley, in cycles of change

Spring: The alley blushes green with new life,
Viola sororia carpeting cracks,
while downspouts giggle with thawed laughter.
Rains draw worms from the earth,
only for robins to pluck them from puddles.

Summer: Heat breathes thick against brick walls.
Taraxacum officinale sends its parachutes skyward,
while ants march toward melting popsicles,
their paths mirrored by sweat tracing human brows.

Autumn: Leaves spill their colors in the gutter,
a compost of amber and russet hues.
Virginia creeper paints walls crimson,
its five-fingered grip loosening in the chill.
Rain returns in bursts,
drawing steam from asphalt like ghostly sighs.

Winter: Ice etches patterns on the pavement,
frost cracks widen the concrete's memory.
Snow muffles sound, blanketing waste
and wild in a fleeting purity.
The alley waits,
its time bound to seasons it cannot keep.

8.3 Water's Singular Story

The alley is a tributary to a greater story,
its puddles mere fragments of a boundless whole.
Here, water does not "belong"—
it moves, pauses, evaporates,
rejoins clouds that carry yesterday's rains
to tomorrow's soil.

In the alley, it is a shapeshifter:
a mirror for a passing bird,
a slick danger beneath hurried feet,
a ghost rising as steam
to rejoin the endless, singular history.

No river is alone,
no drop confined to a single place.
The alley teaches this:
that every storm is borrowed,
that every trickle carries the world.

9 Human Trace and Waste



The alley will provide.

The sign shouts: "NO GARBAGE PICKING,"
a mandate etched in bold defiance,
but someone, an unseen hand, a poet of resistance,
scratched out its certainty to say "KNOW GARBAGE PICK-
ING."

A lesson, perhaps, for those who pass by,
to glean wisdom from waste,
to understand what is discarded,

is never truly lost.

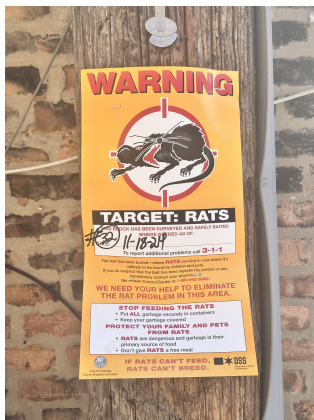
The alley is a palimpsest of use and refusal.
Cardboard kingdoms rise and fall,
shaped by cats, squirrels, and the wind

The Hyde Park bike leans like a relic,
its frame tangled with vines,
chains locked as if in protest,
its purpose forgotten by humans
but adopted by vines and beetles alike.

I have gleaned here too.
From the alley's offerings: a desk chair,
a reclining chair worn with stories,
two desks that now carry new labors,
a chalkboard smudged with faded lessons,
boxes and crafting materials left in wait
for hands willing to make them useful again.

The alley will provide.
Not by design but by endurance,
where broken becomes shelter,
and waste becomes renewal.

10 Poison and Extermination



Warnings etched in fear and baited traps

TARGET: RATS

the sign declares,
its bold font a battle cry.

**This block has been surveyed,
safely baited,
DED as of 11-18-24.**

Beneath, the alley whispers its rebuttal:
Where rats find poison,
robins find berries,
and dandelions root near the edges of traps.

Rat bait buried, hidden,
yet not hidden enough.
Children's laughter rings near forgotten corners,
and the cautionary numbers glow,
a grim reminder:

To report additional problems, call 3-1-1.

The alley persists despite the warnings,
its cycles entangled with those it poisons:
crows picking at limp tails,
fungi breaking down forgotten corpses.
The rat returns, as it always does,
because the alley cannot refuse its meal.

10.1 Common Rat Poisons and Precautions

Anticoagulants: Block vitamin K synthesis, leading to internal bleeding in rats (e.g., Warfarin).

Neurotoxins: Cause paralysis or death by affecting the nervous system (e.g., Bromethalin).

Cholecalciferol: Elevates calcium to toxic levels in the bloodstream, affecting organs.

Precautions for Urban Wildlife and Pets:

- Use bait stations to reduce exposure risk to non-target animals.
- Monitor areas for secondary poisoning signs, especially in predatory species like hawks or raccoons.

Rituals

Understanding the Alleyway

For CAConrad CAConrad 2021

Stand at the entrance of the alleyway. Close your eyes and take three deep breaths, feeling the transition from one world (your home or street) into this other, often-overlooked space. Imagine the alley as a place with layers of life and energy—both seen and unseen, past and present. Open your eyes and greet the alley as though you're entering a place with ancient significance. Walk around your alley without interruption for 10-15 minutes. During this time, watch for any movement—birds hopping, insects, people passing, the wind carrying debris. Note what you see, letting your observations focus on how life interacts with waste and infrastructure. Write a few lines describing each observed action.

As you slowly walk through the alley, run your hands along various surfaces: brick walls, fences, metal, concrete, soil. Notice the textures and the temperature of each surface. Record words or short phrases in your notebook describing how each feels, like “cool grit of concrete” or “rough wood holding warmth.” With your small container or bag, collect fragments of the alleyway—a piece of glass, a leaf, a scrap of paper, or a discarded

object. These are your “artifacts,” representing the transience and permanence of the alley. Note each item’s condition and placement as if you were an archaeologist uncovering a hidden history. What story might each artifact tell? How has it arrived here? You may have a talkative neighbor pass by, don’t feel bad about shooing them away, **YOU ARE A POET AND YOU ARE BUSY**. Write down every sound, from the hum of cars to the rustle of leaves. If possible, return to this exercise at a different time of day, noting the shifts in activity and atmosphere. Consider these sounds as part of the alleyway’s hidden ecosystem. What voices are in the alley’s “chorus”? Note how human sounds (a distant conversation, passing car) blend or clash with natural ones (birds, the wind).

Walk slowly through the alley again, noticing the resilience of plants pushing through cracks, insects thriving in discarded items, and birds nesting in eaves. Reflect on the alley’s resilience, its ability to support life despite its seemingly marginal status. As you walk, mentally repeat, “This is a place of life and return.” Jot down any phrases or thoughts that emerge from this mantra. Revisit the entrance of the alley. Stand still, close your eyes, and thank the space for its resilience, the life it holds, and the perspective it has shared with you. Breathe deeply, and as you exhale, imagine yourself releasing any preconceptions of what makes a space “alive.” When you open your eyes, write a single sentence that captures what the alleyway has taught you. This sentence can serve as a title or final line for your poem.

Using your notes from each step, construct a poem that blends your sensory observations, the resilience of life, and the strange beauty of this in-between space.

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